

Play it again: Instant replay makes its return

Dave Goldberg
Associated Press

PHOENIX — Upon further and further and further review, instant replay is back in the NFL for the 1999 season.

The league's owners, who had killed replay every year for the last seven, overwhelmingly approved a new system Wednesday that will give coaches two challenges per game, with "a replay assistant" to determine if something is to be reviewed in the final two minutes of each half.

The referee on the field will make the final decision.

But unlike the system in effect from 1986-91, it's not intended to cover routine mistakes.

"We are implementing this system to correct the major, major, big mistake," said Seattle

NFL

coach Mike Holmgren, co-chairman of the competition committee, which came up with the plan.

The action comes after a season marked by several high-profile mistakes. It even led commissioner Paul Tagliabue to propose bringing it back for the playoffs, a move that was turned down.

Wednesday's vote was 28-3, the most overwhelming vote for replay since it first came up in 1986. The three "no" votes came from Cincinnati, the New York Jets and Arizona, while the New York Giants, who had voted against it every year, were among the "yes" votes.

That was primarily the reason why replay wasn't put in for longer than one year.

"There were several teams that were traditionally against it

that voted for it this time," said the other co-chairman, Rich McKay of Tampa Bay, another team that was often against replay. "They wanted to see how it works for a year before we put it in for a longer period."

Under the system to be used, coaches will have to act in the 40 seconds between the time a play ends and the ball is put back into play again to make the challenge. All said they would rely on word from an assistant upstairs.

"That won't be a problem," Holmgren said. "We always get five voices at once shouting, 'Yell at someone.'"

The referee on the field will then review the play. If he turns down the challenge, the team making it will lose a timeout. If he upholds the challenge, the team will retain the timeout.

In the final two minutes of

each half, the replay assistant — probably a retired official — will stop the game if he sees a call that might be challenged, and the same procedure will be followed. The replay assistant's challenge will extend into any overtime.

That idea, which swayed the final votes to get over the total of 24 needed for approval, came from commissioner Paul Tagliabue.

"The main thing the coaches objected to was the last two minutes," Tagliabue said.

So he proposed the system in which the last two minutes of each half would be overseen by the replay assistant.

He added that George Young, the league's vice president for football operations, then told him that might break the logjam and get the votes.

Ditka has saintly deal on table for Browns

PHOENIX — Mike Ditka has made it known: He wants Texas running back Ricky Williams carrying the ball for the New Orleans Saints, and he's willing to do anything to get him.

Even trade all six of his draft picks to the Cleveland Browns for the first overall pick.

"I'm willing to do whatever we have to do," Ditka said Wednesday at the NFL's annual meetings. "I'm willing to give the lock, stock and barrel, but nobody is willing to do it."

The Browns will listen, but don't expect them to jump.

First, the Saints do not have a second-round pick; they traded it to St. Louis for wide receiver Eddie Kennison.

In addition, the Saints' first-round pick is the 12th overall, and Browns coach Chris Palmer said that is not high enough for the Browns to select one of the top four quarterbacks coming out — Kentucky's Tim Couch, Syracuse's Donovan McNabb, Oregon's Akili Smith or Central Florida's Daunte Culpepper.

Even Ditka himself said he doubted the Browns would take his offer.

Winning not so simple

Beechcroft takes advantage of its size, Falls' faltering

Tim Gebhardt
Chronicle Telegram

BOWLING GREEN — It seemed so simple.

Put the ball in from the foul line and rebound the missed shots.

Elementary basketball.

But for Olmsted Falls, that simple plan became almost painful as the Bulldogs' Division II regional semifinal game wound down Wednesday night against Columbus Beechcroft at Bowling Green State University.

Falls was 4 of 12 from the foul line and was outrebounded 12-2 in the final period. Beechcroft won 69-58 despite falling behind 15-2 at the outset.

"The free throws were a headache tonight," said Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donahue. "The first five, six games this year we were shooting 75 percent (from the line).

"If we hit our free throws

early in the game we could be looking at a different outcome."

"It's hard to defend height sometimes," Donahue said. "Maybe our legs got a little tired. When you're in there trying to go against a 6-8 kid (DeLano Thomas) ... we had no one who could defend him. They got some easy layups."

Falls started as though it would blow Beechcroft right back to Columbus. Manzie Williams drained three straight 3-pointers and the Bulldogs were off and running.

"There was no question we were ready to play," said Donahue. "It may not have looked that way in the second half. I think we got them playing a little too quick in the first half. In the second half, they got us playing too quick."

"They were anxious," said Cougar coach Joe Dudas of his team's start. "They took that out

on the floor. We picked up the intensity (defensively) in the second half. We just tried to play better defense in the halfcourt."

Beechcroft caught Falls at the beginning of the fourth period and once it grabbed the lead, it never looked back.

"There's not a whole lot of teams that play better team basketball than we do," Donahue said. "If we'd have stayed as a team and worked as a team, it would have been a little different."

"They got us out of that which is a credit to them."

"They did a nice job on Manzie (Williams) the second half," Donahue added. "They made us work harder in the second half."

"We just want to get back home (Columbus)," Dumas said. "This is first regional game we've ever won. We want to get back to where we're five minutes away instead of two hours."



TOM MAHL / CHRONICLE

ON THE MOVE: Olmsted Falls guard Larry Mucha drives on Beechcroft's Marchello Cox during Wednesday's Division II regional basketball game at Bowling Green State University.

BOWLING SCORES

SUNDAY SOCIALIZERS: Moans and Groans 52-25, Strikes Again 45-32, Classic Mishits 41-36, The Go Getters 40-37, Strike Force 37-40, Gooey Bowers 34-43, B.J. and Company 32-45, The Sucks 27-60.

500/600 series: Doug Hayes 625, Bob Rieth 606, Maria Costello 577, Ten Hayes 563, Moans & Groans 2130

SHAKE, RATTLE AND ROLL: Born To Be Wild 45½-24½, All Shook Up 45½-24½, Twist and Shouters 41-29, Ghost Rattlers 40-30, Dream Weavers 39-41, Sugar Sugar 36-34, Wanderers 37-33, Our Ding A Lings 34-36, Wild Things 27-45, Great Balls of Fire 23-47, Money Monies 22-48, Alley Cops 21-49.

600 series: Dewey Justice 684, Diane Egly 685, Mike Bedock 643, Rich Rigger 678, Josh Justice 616, Kris Huddleston 579, Born To Be Wild 2528

POT LUCK COUPLES: Kathy's Clowns 28-7, Spotters 23 12, TDBB 21-14, The Riddlers 21-14, Fireflies 19-16, The Card Players 19-16, Dynamite Duos 18-17, Wolf Pack 11-24, Lucky Strikers 9-26, The Islanders 6-29

600 series: Kerry Smith 611, Dawn Ankns 629, Kathy's Clowns 2124.

HITS AND MISSES CPLs: Lander Antique 44-28, Paul's Beverage Warehouse 43-29, Annette's Pizza 40-32, Jaworski Aluminum 39-33, Tough Enough 34-38, A-Team 15-56.

500/600 series: Clarence Burnett 663, Dot Glover 501, Tough Enough 2080.

ELKS FRI. NITE CPLs: Double Trouble 42-21, Hi Rollers 40-23, Dirt Bags 38-25, Blondie and Greys 27-36, Who Cares 23-40, Ten Pin Thumpers 19-44.

500/600 series: Ted Schultz 690, Nancy Blackburn 536, Double Trouble 2050.

SUN. ODD COUPLES: Cozart-Mahilo 17-3, Lewis-Smith 15-5, Dezzo-Shook 11-9, Beal-Webber 10-10, Barkel-Tanner 9-11, Meecha-Rose 8-12, Root-Wright 5-15, Bridgett-Seymour 5-15.

600/700 series: Rudy Cozart 717, Lisa Mahilo 611, Al Mahilo 701, Bert Shook 650, Tom Meecha 628, Al Lewis 611, Cozart Mahilo 2560

ELYRIA EAGLES #431: AAA Appliance 51-19, Col. H. Roberts 46-24, Don 45-25, Amvets #32 37-33, Ene Shore Mortgage 34-36, Stoney's 31-39, Majestic Realty 31-39.

600 series: Bud Schuck 693, Dean Rutter 679, E.J. Gardiner 651, Mike Komer 642, Ken Barr 630, Horshel White 625, Tim Kurlay 617, Dennis Mahl 614, Ed Gardiner 31-39.

B.C. FRI. NITE "900": Elyna Bowling Ctr. 37-19, Ross Family Auction 31-25, Smink Electric 31-25, Ralph's Electric 28-28, Looper's Barbers 27-29, Siman Chrysler 26-30, LaPorte Inn 24-32, S.W.A. 20-36.

600/700 series: Dean Neuschaefer 731, Joe Schuster 721, Dave Rucker 696, John Yucka 698, Tracy Hill 673, Darrel Maddock 668, Barry Spreng 664, Jim "Stretch" Moran 656, Ralph's Place 3309

HAPPY HOUR: C.R. Lanes 50-6, Family Jewels 32-24, Papa Johns 23-33, Bob Morris 0-56.

500/600 series: Anthony Valentin 694, Shirley Justice 567, Joe Corley 681, Mike Bedock 676, Lil Baxter 551, C.R. Lanes 2618

Comets' Ewald chooses Dayton

AMHERST — Michael Ewald, an offensive lineman from Amherst, received confirmation Tuesday night that he will get a grant-in-aid to play football this fall at the University of Dayton.

Ewald, a 6-foot-3, 275-pound offensive tackle, was a second-team All-Ohio selection in Division II last fall. He was also first-team

All-Lorain County, All-Northeast District and second-team All-Southwestern Conference.

Dayton, which is Division I-AA but plays in a league of Division III schools, is bound by league rules to give financial grants according to need rather than full scholarships.

"Mike was one of the best offensive linemen we've ever had," Amherst coach Jeff Riesen said. "To give you an idea how valuable he was to us, we flip-flopped him from the right side to the left and back depending on the play we were running."

"He had great speed for a big man and good feet. Most college recruiters are more interested in foot speed than upper-body size. Mike was very adept at pulling."

"To me, Mike is a living example of how important off-season weight workouts are. He made tremendous improvement from his junior season by working his rear off in the weight room during the offseason. It just shows what a young man can do if he is committed."

Ewald, who also competes in the discus and shot put in track and field, has a 3.0 grade-point average. He plans to go into criminal justice.

FALLS

From D1

To be sure, Gansey blocked the game's first shot, which was by Thomas, and had two more blocks the rest of the way.

Gansey's opening block heralded the start of good times for the Bulldogs.

The Cougars' Marchello Cox scored a putback to give them a 2-0 lead 41 seconds into the game, but Falls reeled off 15 straight points over the next three and a half minutes.

Williams drained back-to-back 3-pointers, Sean Radigan sandwiched two fastbreak layups around a third Williams three, and Larry Mucha scored on the long end of another fastbreak.

Falls led 19-10 after a quarter and 36-28 at the half.

"In the first half, we played our game," Donohue said. "In the second half, we played their game. They played more athletically than we did, and they have better athletes."

Beechcroft put together a four-point spurt to start the third quarter and another to end it, which left the Bulldogs hanging on by a thread, 49-47, heading into the final eight minutes.

Olmsted Falls, in deepening foul trouble, sent Cougars to the line a dozen times in the last 4:05, and they made nine of them to ice it.

"We were ready to play the whole game," Donohue said. "And I'll say this. They played their rear ends off in 24 games this year. They came out focused every night."

Gansey followed Williams' 21

points with 19 and was the only other Bulldog in double figures. Gansey also had nine rebounds.

Thomas scored 20 points for Beechcroft, Damien Lee 17 and Cox and Lamar Woods 13 apiece.

BEECHCROFT (19-4)							
Players	GA	G	FA	FT	F	P	
DeLano Thomas	15	6	7	8	6	2	20
Damen Lee	11	6	4	3	0	0	17
Marchello Cox	10	6	2	1	1	1	13
Lamar Woods	9	5	2	2	4	13	
Matt Jones	3	3	0	0	0	5	6
J.C. Zimmerman	2	0	0	0	0	3	0
Eric Bradley	2	0	0	0	0	3	0
TOTALS	52	27	16	12	18	68	
O FALLS (23-3)							
Players	GA	G	FA	FT	F	P	
Manzie Williams	20	8	2	0	2	21	
Mike Gansey	17	9	4	0	0	19	
Sean Radigan	7	3	2	2	2	8	
Greg Koch	6	1	0	0	0	4	
Larry Mucha	4	1	0	0	5	2	
Sean Williams	1	1	0	0	0	4	2
Jake Schneider	1	1	0	0	0	1	2
Jeremy Holland	1	0	0	0	0	0	0
TOTALS	57	24	12	4	17	58	

Three-point field goals, Beechcroft: Lee 2, Woods, O Falls M Williams 5, Gansey.

SCORE BY QUARTERS					
	1	2	3	4	T
Beechcroft	10	18	19	22	— 69
O Falls	19	17	13	9	— 58

SPARTANS

From D1

Toledo Christian is going to have a varsity team it seemed like the right time to get in," Lorain Catholic coach Thom Lesiecki said.

Lorain Catholic joins Oregon Cardinal Stritch, Toledo Ottawa Hills and Lakeside Danbury — three teams Lorain Catholic played last year — and Toledo Christian, which will field a varsity team for the first time.

"It has been a long time since we have had the opportunity to play for a conference championship," Lesiecki said. "Since our players found out about finally belonging to a conference, the excitement level has exploded."

The Spartans were 5-5 last season, beating Ottawa Hills 38-22 and Lakeside Danbury 42-38 while losing 39-0 to Cardinal Stritch.

When Lesiecki learned the TAAC was adding Toledo Christian to the conference and would have a championship for the first time, he decided to approach the league coaches about LC's joining.

"They welcomed us with open arms," said Lesiecki, who is just as excited as his players to have a chance to play for a title.

The Spartans dropped Lutheran East from their '99 schedule to clear a spot for Toledo Christian. The Spartans will become the largest school in

the conference and will bring some competitive play to the TAAC.

"The conference is pretty strong," Lesiecki said. "Two of the three teams finished with only two losses so it will be a challenge for us to finish at the top."

Lorain Catholic competed in the Erie Coast Conference from 1978-86, before the league disbanded. Prior to that, Lorain Catholic was a member of the North Central League.

The rest of the Spartan teams will stay independent as of now.

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